



Vital cog: Pooja Vastrakar has been an important part of India's pace attack, but her staggered availability due to injury deprived the team of the benefits her aggressive pace typically provides. GETTY IMAGES

Great planning, poor execution

India's campaign could be encapsulated by its approach to the No. 3 batting position. In the 2023 winter fixtures against England and Australia, Richa Ghosh emerged as a potential candidate for the spot. Dayalan Hemalatha's impressive hitting in the Women's Premier League (WPL) made her another contender, while Uma Chetry and Sajeevan Sajana were also tried during the Asia Cup.

In the warm-up matches before the World Cup, Harmanpreet surprised many by coming in at No. 3. Ahead of the opener against New Zealand, coach Muzumdar cheekily said, "If you see the scorecard (from the warm-ups), you'll know who's our No. 3."

However, after the first two games, Harmanpreet returned to her usual No. 4 spot, raising questions about the management's backtracking. Jemimah Rodrigues, a versatile player willing to adapt to

any role, ended up floating in the top order, focusing on maximising runs rather than stabilising a shaky batting line-up. She was arguably better suited for in the slow conditions. Richa's poor form was evident, scoring just 19 runs across four games at an average of 6.33. Experiments with her at No. 3 long abandoned, she slotted in in her usual role as a finisher. But she couldn't deliver in the crunch game against Australia.

In this spin-friendly World Cup, seamers still thrived. Megan Schutt and Marizanne Kapp enjoyed success, complementing their teams'

spinners. For India, Renuka Singh and Arundhati Reddy took seven wickets each in four games, particularly notable in Pooja Vastrakar's absence due to injury. Asha Sobhana (five wickets for 65 runs in three games) and Shreyanka Patil (four wickets for 84 runs in four games) were crucial in the middle overs, though Deepti Sharma was expensive, taking four wickets for 113 runs across four games. Harmanpreet's six-bowler strategy left the team a batter short, and the decision to leave out Radha Yadav, a proven all-rounder, felt like a self-goal.



A question for the future is whether India values Harmanpreet more as a captain or a power-hitter. While she has the backing of the selectors and coach, her ability to turn games around with the bat cannot be overlooked.